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 **T-storm 93/75 • Tomorrow: Sunny and less humid 86/68 B24** *Democracy Dies in Darkness* **SUNDAY, JULY 20, 2025 • \$6**

Paring at State Dept. led by club of outsiders

Critics say deep damage wrought by disrupters willing to ‘break stuff’

BY ADAM TAYLOR,
HANNAH NATANSON
AND JOHN HUDSON

The Trump administration’s dramatic reorganization of the State Department, including this month’s firing of more than 1,300 workers, was engineered primarily by a handful of political appointees lacking extensive diplomatic experience and chosen for their “fidelity” to the president and willingness to “break stuff” on his behalf, according to people with knowledge of the process.

Proponents of the initiative have declared its execution a historic success, overcoming years of resistance from a career workforce averse to major change. Critics say it was done arbitrarily, in furtherance of Trump’s polarizing brand of conservatism, and will damage the United States’ standing in the world by shedding invaluable expertise across the department.

Central to the effort was Jeremy Lewin, a 28-year-old former agent of Elon Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service who earlier this year oversaw its rapid, messy dismantling of the U.S. Agency for International Development (USAID) — one of the administration’s first and most drastic acts to impose President Donald Trump’s “America’s First” agenda on the government’s foreign policy institutions.

Lewin and his teammates at the State Department have faced withering blowback from Democrats and outraged employees, SEE **STATE DEPT.** ON **A10**

Ukraine: Putin sticks to war even as Russia’s global clout wanes. **A16**

The Tour de France’s toughest stage



MARTIN DIVISEK/EPA/SHUTTERSTOCK

Tadej Pogacar, the overall leader in the yellow jersey and the Tour de France’s defending champion, rides through Barèges during Saturday’s difficult 14th stage. Pogacar finished in second but increased his overall lead. **Story, B2**

Epstein story latest in long line of tests for Trump

BY NATALIE ALLISON

Nearly two weeks after President Donald Trump and his administration announced they had nothing more to say about Jeffrey Epstein’s criminal case, the topic continues to dog him, presenting a potential new political liability at the six-month mark of his presidency as Trump tries to sell more Americans on his accomplishments.

The uproar around Epstein escalated Thursday with a report in the Wall Street Journal that refocused attention on Trump’s own

Unlikely to sink survivor of many scandals, but it could be a political drag

relationship with him. It’s the latest scandal to touch a public figure who has weathered many of them, both in and out of office, yet managed to return to Washington after his 2020 defeat with even more power than before.

Despite the clamor surrounding Epstein from within the presi-

dent’s political base and beyond, there is no indication so far that this is the scandal that will sink Trump any more than the “Access Hollywood” tape of 2016, or being found guilty in a criminal trial last year over hush money payments to a porn star. Trump won presidential elections after both.

But Epstein clearly has posed a problem for the White House. At minimum, it has been a distraction at a time when Trump wants to tout his legislative victories. If it continues to grab public attention, it could pose a more significant threat at a time when Trump’s

standing with the public already has been on the decline, though polling shows him steady with his own party.

Trump lashed out at the Journal’s story after it was published, threatening to sue both the newspaper and its owner, Rupert Murdoch, who has been an important, although inconstant, political ally. SEE **TRUMP** ON **A11**

The Sunday Take: President loses ground amid the Epstein saga. **A2**

‘I don’t draw pictures’: Several Trump doodles have been sold. **A3**

Cuts to public radio and TV may hit hardest in rural areas

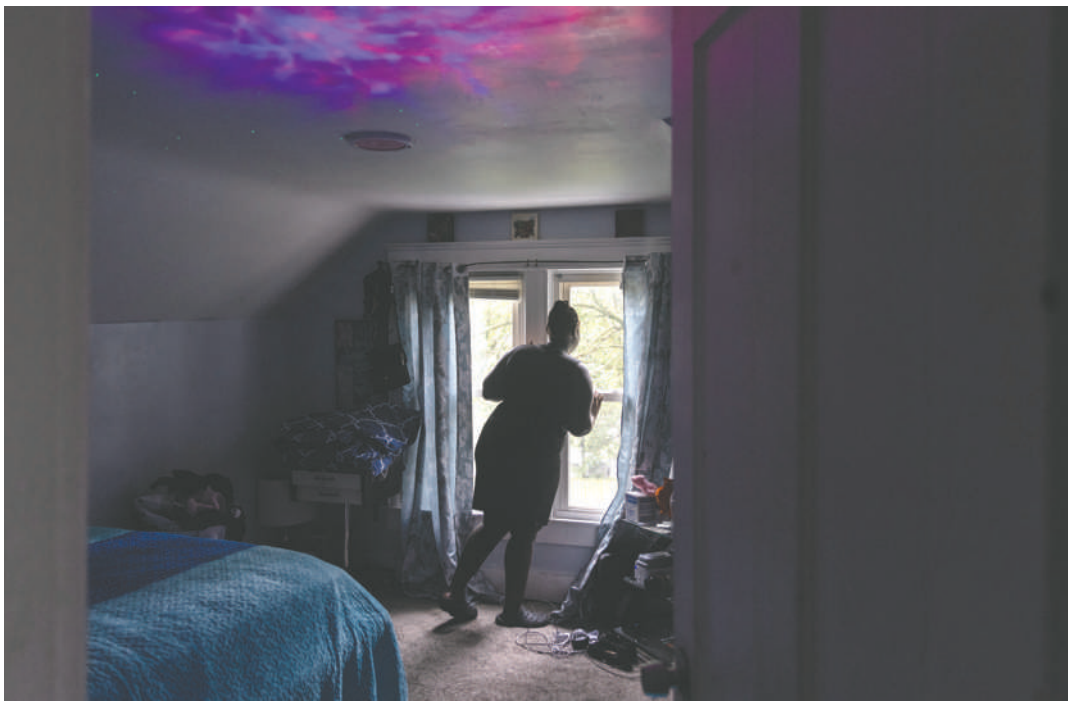
BY SCOTT NOVER
AND KARIN BRULLIARD

When a 7.3-magnitude earthquake rumbled beneath the Bering Sea on Wednesday 50 miles south of Sand Point, Alaska, authorities sent their first tsunami warnings directly to the nearest public radio station, KUCB in the Aleutian Islands town of Unalaska. Along with other local NPR and PBS stations, it immediately broadcast alerts for residents and tourists to get to higher ground. By the time the Alaska Emergency Management Agency contacted Sand Point and other island communities, the word was already out, said the agency’s director, Bryan Fisher.

The earthquake struck as senators in Washington were debating whether to eliminate all of the \$1.1 billion in federal funding for public broadcasting set to be doled out over the next two years to PBS, NPR, and local radio and television stations across the country.

“If the funding goes away and KUCB can’t stay on the air, we lose that vital warning channel to the public, mariners, and tourists in our coastal communities,” Fisher said.

The Senate narrowly passed the bill, which rescinds previously appropriated funds. Sen. Lisa SEE **MEDIA** ON **A7**



MADDIE MCGARVEY/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Sarah Vital, a Haitian immigrant, looks out the window of her bedroom in Springfield, Ohio.

CRACKS IN THE DREAM

As uncertainty clouds their future, a Haitian family’s Ohio home fractures

BY DANIELLE PAQUETTE
AND OBED LAMY
IN SPRINGFIELD, OHIO

She hadn’t seen cracks like that since the earthquake. Now they snaked up her buttercream dining room walls and etched tiny ravines in the ceiling.

“Crazy,” Fernande said to her husband as they eyed the damage. “They’re driving me crazy.”

Clearly, they’d spread. Like the scars on all those buildings back home, she told a construction-worker friend who, as a fellow Haitian, understood. He’d also survived the 7.0 megatremors that leveled much of their island nation.

Fernande had figured calamity wouldn’t trail them to America, land of the free, home of the Kardashian opulence on her teenage daughter’s TikTok feed.

Not that glitz had ever been the goal. Her family of five sought the basics in southwestern Ohio: Assembly line work. Sunday service. A banged-up Honda minivan. A jar of faux carnations. Safety.

Their only indulgence had been the house on Chestnut Avenue. Slate gray with a wrap-around porch, the century-old Folk Victorian hit the market in SEE **HOME** ON **A8**

Families in Venezuela greet freed prisoners with joy, grief

Relatives of those sent to a Salvadoran megaprison want answers for ordeal

BY MARÍA LUISA PAÚL,
SILVIA FOSTER-FRAU,
TEO ARMUS AND CAMILLE
RODRÍGUEZ MONTILLA

Angela Leal went to bed Thursday and recited the prayer she has whispered to herself each night for the last four months. She asked God to keep her husband safe, to give him strength and to bring him home.

The next morning, she woke to the answer she’d been waiting for: The United States had made a deal with the Venezuelan government to send more than 250 Venezuelans jailed in El Salvador back home. The men deported from the U.S. would be landing on two flights in exchange for the release of 10 American citizens and permanent U.S. residents imprisoned in Venezuela.

“I’m still in shock,” Leal said through tears in an interview. “There are just no words to explain this happiness.”

The families of the Venezuelan migrants sent to a Salvadoran megaprison had been waiting for answers since March. The Trump administration accused their relatives of being members of the Tren de Aragua gang and put them on planes to El Salvador.



FAMILY PHOTO

“I’m still in shock,” said Angela Leal, 22, whose husband, Luis Marciano Silva, had been deported to El Salvador.

Some were featured in videos shot by the Salvadoran government, showing their brothers, fathers and sons shackled and hunched as they were forced into the Central American country’s Terrorism Confinement Center. Once inside, the men disappeared from their families’ lives and the public view, their names gone from the U.S. government’s detainee locator system.

Across Venezuela and the United States, the news of their sudden return brought excitement and relief — but also resurfaced feelings of frustration and anger at the ordeal their families have experienced.

“I’m happy, but at the same time I want there to be justice for what they did to him,” said Juan Terán, whose son, Carlos Daniel Terán, had entered the United SEE **FAMILIES** ON **A18**

SPORTS

As WNBA players seek better pay, they dial back their social activism. **B1**

BUSINESS

New state laws pave way for consumers to use gold as legal tender. **B9**



BOOK WORLD

Honorée Fanonne Jeffers’s essays often sting — but always sing.

METRO

Pressure mounts on D.C. Council to hold vote on RFK Stadium. **B17**



TRAVEL

Bad Bunny takes aim at bad behavior from tourists in Puerto Rico.

ARTS & STYLE

Why the Silver Surfer is the superhero for our cosmically fraught times.

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